

Vertical Slice Design Document

A group of travelers went on a hike in the desert. Suddenly the ground beneath them collapsed. They wake up and figure out that they are in an ancient temple, and they need to escape. They can participate in puzzles, challenges, time-limit events, mind-challenging riddles, and many more in order to obtain the gems for the temple rooms to open.

Initially, the players wake up in an ancient temple room. They figure out that they went unconscious after a fall. They see that there is no way to go back. They notice empty holes on a stone wall and a symbol of the sun next to them. The third socket is not empty, it contains a crystal with a symbol that does not look familiar. They will soon discover what the holes represent.

There are eight main puzzles. Solving each one the players obtain a crystal with a symbol engraved on it. The symbols represent each one of the planets in our solar system. The objective is to place all of the obtained crystals in the correct order from the sun. There is also a puzzle that would provide them with a hint for ordering the planets, i.e., symbols. When they obtain the first crystal, the players would notice that it looks like the one that is already in one of the holes. They figure out that they need to place the acquired crystal into one of the empty sockets. Now, the goal is evident to the players. We can see how solving all the puzzles will be done to obtain elements for the final puzzle, filling the holes and opening the way out.

For the vertical slice, we help the players with some hints that are explained in simpler terms than in a real game. In addition, their way out is opened after placing only four or five out of all the required crystals. We can adapt that depending on the size of the group and their performance. However, the crystals still need to be ordered, so the players still need to solve the final puzzle. Since they do not need all of the crystals for the vertical slice, the players will be able to leave an encountered puzzle and go to the next one, if they think it would be easier or less time-consuming. Unlike in the real game where each puzzle would be in a different room, all the puzzles are placed in the same room. The players will not waste time switching rooms and recalling what they could use from the previous rooms.

There are many different types of puzzles that require players to use logic, pattern and color recognition, deciphering skills, sense of touch, etc. Some of them affect you or your team for the rest of the game. For instance, the one who drinks a wrong potion will stay mute for the rest of the game. There is a flow and a connection of puzzles. In order to do a certain puzzle, you would require to do something from the previous one, e.g. obtaining a certain object or a tip. Also, you could not enter to some rooms before finishing certain puzzles. In the vertical slice, all of the puzzles are available in the same room, the players can choose which ones they will do but also a certain order is presented to them. So, if they skip something, they can still do the other puzzle but perhaps they missed a hint. However, they can see their progress by obtaining crystals and knowing how many they need in order to escape.

The temple contains just the remains of the ancient world with many rooms, some of them containing puzzles, some containing tips, and other just trying to confuse you and slow you down. For the playtest, besides puzzles, there are only a few objects in the room since we do not want to distract the players. All the instructions are visible to players for each of the puzzles, and they see the crystal next to each one. It is clear to the players what they can obtain after solving a certain puzzle.

Players are immersed in the story. The parts of the temple are shaking and collapsing. Each one of the puzzles is time-sensitive, e.g., walls are shrinking so the players know they need to hurry. It also has a positive effect, reminding the players to not lose much time on certain puzzles, since they can skip something and still manage to escape, in a playtest.

After conducting a playtest in the way explained above, we gathered some feedback and changed a few things. At first, we did not implement timers so players would spend much time on one or two puzzles, and they were not able to escape in time. For example, the letters could fade so they cannot waste anymore time on a certain puzzle. We halved the number of pictures for one of the puzzles. It took a lot of time prior to doing so and it did not affect the puzzle itself. We noticed that the color pattern was not so evident to players, so we put a tip inside of the sand boxes. For the sphinx riddle, we added tips if the players guess incorrectly, so they are pointed in the right direction. In the poem, we highlighted some of the words so it is faster for the players to grasp what should be done. Besides that, we were testing different time limits, two or three minutes depending on the puzzle. All the changes were made between the playtests, so the later groups knew what to do and managed to escape. Also, resetting the room was easy. We put the obtained crystals back to their original spots, next to the corresponding puzzles. The potion bottles are refilled. We put the objects back into the sand boxes and return any other items that may be moved.

Hence, there are no major changes that would affect the puzzles, but just a few adaptations so the players can finish everything in time and still have a full experience. In conclusion, the escape room's vertical slice successfully captures the essence of a thrilling adventure within the ancient temple. The carefully crafted puzzles, time-sensitive challenges, and immersive storytelling create a dynamic and engaging experience. Through playtesting and thoughtful adjustments, the escape room offers a balance between difficulty and enjoyment. With its interconnected puzzles and a race against time, the escape room provides a satisfying and memorable journey, leaving players eager for the full experience of unlocking the mysteries of the ancient temple.

Puzzles

PUZZLE 1: Poem and hidden message

Among ten face-up pictures pick five that correspond to the poem. On the reverse side of each there is a letter. By selecting five correct pictures the player gets a 5-letter word that is a password.

The password is TOMBS, correct pictures are SCARAB, RIVER, CAT, WINGS, JACKAL

Poem:

*Beneath the sun's eternal gaze, secrets whisper through the stones,
Ancient guardians, silent keepers of the ancient thrones.*

*A **scarab's** journey, through sands and realms unknown,
Unearth the essence of its flight, where ancient stories are sown.
Amidst the whispers of the Nile, where life's **river** gently flows,
Seek the reflection of **feline** eyes, where the lunar mystery glows.*

***Wings** of divine messengers, soaring on winds untold,
Carry the message of the **jackal**, in moonlit stories, unfold.
Now, attune to the symphony of ancient whispers,
Let the symbols guide your hands, as destiny shivers.
Five chosen echoes of the past, woven in nature's script,
Unveil the harmony within, where ancient spirits crypt.*

PUZZLE 2: Common Shape, Different Tabs

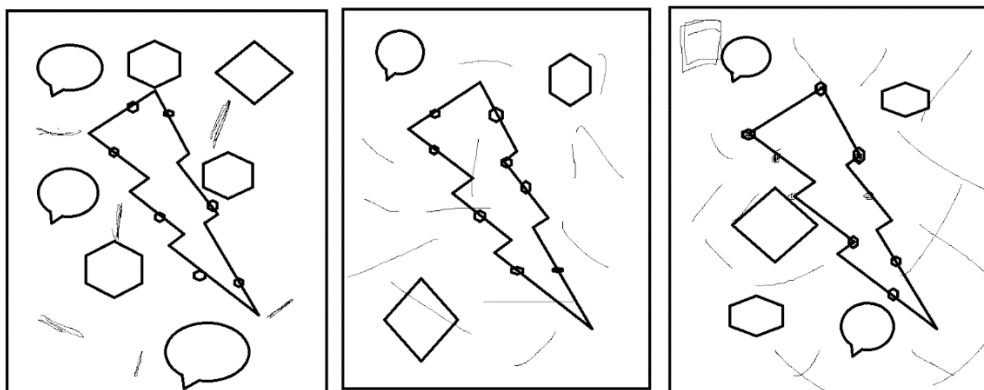
For this puzzle, we have carved out different shapes, forms, and holes in three cardboard plates, with one common hole in all three shapes that depicts a snake with eyes and a tongue.

The players must align, rotate, and orientate all the planks to shine a light through the common hole and find the object depicted since they are given the three planks with random holes in random positions, and they are rotated in all directions.

They can also make use of a flashlight they find in another puzzle, or they might need to have a more difficult time without the flashlight, and just use their eyes to rotate and flip the plates.

The puzzle is easy, the time limit is a minute and once they find the object or what the common hole depicts, they just say it to solve it and then are given the gem of this puzzle.

The sketch is shown in the picture below, and the final puzzle can be seen in the gameplay video.



PUZZLE 3: Treasure boxes

There are four boxes filled with sand. Players can check only 3 of them in search of treasure. One of them contains a crystal, others have dangers or tips for other puzzles.

1. Sand + crystal
2. Sand + tip for the color pattern
3. Sand + flashlight (tip for the puzzle no. 2)
4. Sand + spiders (debuff)

The boxes also contain the color pattern for puzzle number 5.

PUZZLE 4: Mysterious potions

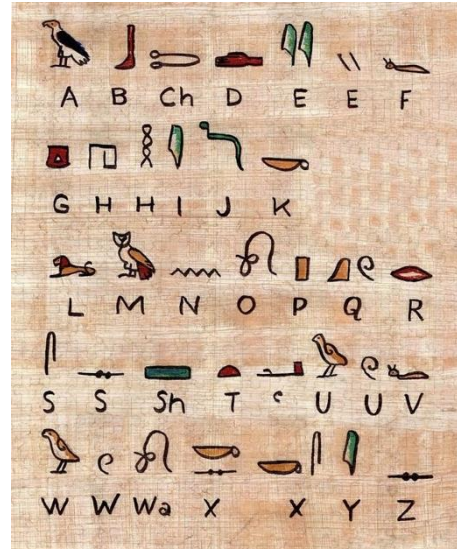
Players have activated a trap; the walls are closing threatening to kill them. Players are presented with 2 potions; one gives super strength the other makes the player mute for the rest of the game. There is a description for each potion that is ciphered. Descriptions are vague on purpose to make the choice harder. Players must decipher the message and drink a correct potion before the time limit runs out.

Messages are:

“Looks sweet and tasty. Is it?”

“Looks mysterious”

Time limit: 60 seconds



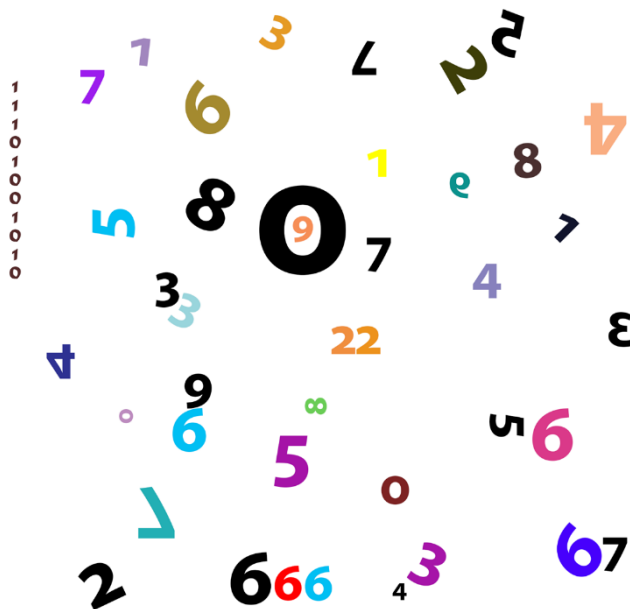
PUZZLE 5: Color coded password.

There is a panel with a series of numbers. Each one is in a different color. There is a pattern of colors present in the room. Color sequences will appear in many places throughout the game. To obtain a code, someone needs to go color by color in order and take the number in a corresponding color.

The password you get can be used for unlocking something else.

COLOR CODE:

YELLOW, GREEN, PINK, RED



PUZZLE 6 (Single): A Sphinx Riddle

Players have three chances to guess the riddle.

First wrong try, the Sphinx tells the person who guessed it that they can't guess again, however, they can still contribute and help their friends.

Second wrong, the sphinx mauls the person who guessed it wrong, and they can't contribute at all to this puzzle, they are unconscious.

Third wrong, the Sphinx disappears, and the puzzle is closed.

The riddle:

I may hold kings and queens, yet I am quick to fall but trickle in some water and I will stand tall. What am I?

Answer: Sandcastle

If the team of explorers guesses right, they obtain a gem.

PUZZLE 7: Logical puzzle.

The players need to guess who each of the persons A, B, and C is. They only have one try since the puzzle only has one solution.

At the outset, heed this:

Discern wisely whom to trust as you navigate the temple's riddles.

The Scribes always speak the truth, while the Deceivers perpetuate lies.

To progress, you must unravel their identities.

A proclaims: "B is a Deceiver."

B asserts: "C is a Deceiver."

C declares: "Both B and I are Scribes."

May your deciphering lead you through the temple's intricate paths.

PUZZLE PIECE X

It's a small box. By looking inside players can see the correct astronomical order of the planets and their symbols.

ENDING PUZZLE: Crystals are represented by planets.

To exit the room, put a minimum of 4 or 5 crystals in the correct astronomical order.

That is a final puzzle, they must arrange the crystals in ascending order so that they can escape the room.

Correct planet order:

Sun - Mercury - Venus - Earth - Mars - Jupiter - Saturn - Uranus - Neptune

